"Thank God!" muttered the captain making the sign of the cross again, "They've managed to save him." He turned to the passengers thronging the railings. "Please do not crowd round the man when he is brought up. He will need immediate medical care." Then he saw the ship's doctor standing with a couple of nurses. A stretcher was also being brought close to the railings.

"Doctor! Is everything ready for the patient?" the captain asked.

"Aye, aye, Captain," nodded the doctor.

The captain moved away to restore order on the ship. I edged close to the doctor and asked, "What will you do to him, doctor? Will he be all right?"

"Aye, I think so. All the water will have to be pumped out of him. He'll have to be given artificial respiration and kept warm."

"How do you pump the water out?" I asked. "We put him on his stomach and massage him until he brings it all up," he replied.

As soon as the rescue team reached the ship, Uncle was placed on the stretcher and rushed to the hospital room. The captain then came to me and said, "Run along now and play with your friends. I'm busy, but will send for you when I'm through. I might even have a surprise for you."

When he turned away, I quietly sneaked into the hospital room to see what they were doing to the patient. Two nurses were scurrying to and fro with trays full of medicines and syringes. Another was rushing off with Uncle's wet clothes. I stopped her and asked if Uncle was conscious. "Not yet," she replied, "but he's better now. He should regain consciousness in a little while."

The ship was still rolling, so I couldn't play any games. I went and sat in a cosy chair in the lounge and started reading a story book. I was feeling drowsy and must have dozed off. The next thing I knew was somebody saying, "Wake up, child. You're Vasantha, aren't you? The Captain wants to see you in his cabin."

I looked up to see a sailor standing before me. It took me a minute to recollect the rescue operation and the captain telling me, "I'll call you afterwards."

I followed the officer eagerly. He left me outside the captain's door, saying, "Go right inside."

I knocked and entered. The captain was standing in the middle of the room. When he saw me, he came forward and literally swept me off my feet. He was still smiling when he put me down.

"You will have plenty to tell your friends, eh? Now close your eyes."

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